

Neanderthals

During the ice age, Europe was inhabited by a race of physically powerful and intelligent people known as Neanderthals. The Neanderthals had large brains, language, clothing, shelters, fire, tools, and maybe even art—but they were not the same species as us. When our own species finally spread from Africa to Europe 40,000 years ago, the Neanderthals vanished.

Homo neanderthalensis

HOE-moe nee-AN-der-thaw-LEN-siss



- **When** 350,000–30,000 years ago (Neogene)
- **Fossil location** Europe and Asia
- **Habitat** Ice age grasslands and woodlands
- **Height** 5 ft 5 in (1.66 m)
- **Diet** Mainly meat

Neanderthals were shorter, stockier, and far stronger than us. Their compact build helped them cope with the cold environment, and their great strength was needed for hunting wild animals as big as mammoths, although they probably scavenged for meat, too. Their brains were at least as big as ours, but their heads were flatter in shape, with a lower, more sloping forehead, a heavy ridge of bone over the eyes, a huge nose, and large jaws that jutted forward.